Material Subjects, Immaterial Bodies

Abhinavagupta's Panentheist Matter

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> The clay pot knows by means of my self and I know by means of the self of the clay pot. . . . Indeed, the clay pot knows by means of that absolute transcendent being and the transcendent deity knows by means of the clay pot.
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> —Somānanda, *Śiva Dṛṣṭi*

Scientific paradigms of the twentieth century, and specifically materialist paradigms, have not only set the parameters of what we take to be possible; they have indeed materially influenced in no small measure how we script the world around us. We can, for instance, thank contemporary scientific materialist reductionist models for an astounding map of the building blocks of matter, molecules and atoms, to wonderful effect in the chemistry of new medical drugs, travel to space, mapping of the genome. And less happily, we owe also to the material progress of scientific reductionism the overwhelming amount of plastics in our oceans. Materialist reductionism tells us that we can reduce just about everything, including chemistry and biology, to the tiny protons and electrons of physics. Beyond, however, the reductive materialism of the hard sciences, like physics and chemistry, the social sciences as well have scripted their own versions of materialism, *imitatio scientia*. With this, anthropology, religious studies, and sociology, for instance, look for explanations of human behavior through materialist reductionist models, simplifying the messy chaos of human religiosity, for example, to neater, more manageable material mechanisms like economic interest or the imperatives of brain biology.[1] Further, on the heels of the mind-boggling success of materialist reductionism, have come new births, of other, even bolder materialisms. For instance, Patricia Churchland's daring expansion into eliminativist materialism waves away the idea of self in a single gesture. The subjective sense of self in this farther-reaching materialist paradigm turns out to be no more than a simple, unfortunate illusion manufactured by an unwitting brain.[2] Meanwhile, materialist paradigms have also exerted powerful influence in political spheres. Indeed, steering the course of whole nations, Marx's historical materialism, and its offshoot dialectical materialism, has mapped the fate of millions under communist Russia and China.[3]

Despite this success, however, the materialist reductionism that has enabled the development of such remarkable advances in technology has since the early part of the twentieth century been grappling with its own incoherencies in the form of the new scientific discoveries reaching into the realm of the very, very small, the domain of quantum physics. The dominant response from the physics community for the latter half of the century has been to cast a blind eye—what David Kaiser pithily described as "shut up and calculate." However, a few physicists recently, including Karen Barad, have worked to make sense out of the incoherencies dogging matter and its entanglements.[4] The results of quantum experiments appear to demand a reincorporation of the observer within conceptual models describing what objectivity and scientific practice mean. In this context, Karen Barad has leveraged the anomalies of quantum mechanics into a coherent theory of subjectivity that links observer and observed in a mutual agency. Agential realism, as she names it, affords agency to both the observer *and* the photon whizzing across space as its trajectory is recorded on a screen by the experimenter/observer. Barad extrapolates from Niels Bohr's understanding of indeterminacy to suggest that observer and phenomenon observed, subject and object, both arise together through a mutual delineation. This is not an interaction, where a separate observer records the movements of an object, the photon, perhaps, changing the course the photon takes through the act of a gaze. Rather, she suggests we understand this as "intra-activity." Intra-activity means that there are not two separate parties, who then interact. Instead, we find that the two, observer and object, emerge in the first place through this very act of engagement, an intra-activity, an emergent entanglement that then allows both subject and object to become manifest into these two separate perspectives. Expanding this theory derived from Bohr's interpretation of quantum mechanics to human relations affords productive and suggestive new models for how humans might coexist with one another, certainly, and also with the wider natural world. And, indeed, it entails that the very meaning of matter dramatically shifts.

Barad's conception of the mutual delineation of subject and object curiously sounds remarkably close to a temporally distant tenth-century Indian proposal. About a millennium before Barad's keen analysis of quantum theory, the Hindu Kashmiri philosopher Somānanda offers—not through science, but theologically inspired—a philosophical formulation of the mutual imbrication of divinity and matter as subject and object. In the nondualist Śaivism of Somānanda's tenth-century philosophy of subjectivity, the consciousness of a mere clay pot gets inseparably entangled with that of his own subjective awareness—and with that of the highest divinity. "The clay pot knows by means of my self and I know by means of the self of the clay pot. . . . Indeed, the clay pot knows by means of that absolute transcendent being and the transcendent deity knows by means of the clay pot,"[5] Somānanda tells us. He is thus entangling the agency and observational capacity of god and humble clay pot with his own. Can the matter of mere clay be so indispensable to the all-encompassing deity, Śiva, who stands as the foundation of subjectivity for his school of thought? Actually Śiva, for Somānanda's philosophical system, represents more than simply a deity, more than the highest deity in a great chain of being. In Somānanda's nondualism Śiva stands less as an entity than an all-pervading principle, characterized in its first movement as *cit*, consciousness. It then unfolds within itself the capacities for will, knowledge, and action and, with these, time as it unfolds, down to the very stuff of matter, the clay that makes up the clay pot.

In this essay I examine this much earlier, radical reworking of the notion of matter, one that bears affinities with some quantum formulations of the mutual implication of observers and the objects they observe. I work here with a medieval tenth- and eleventh-century Indian school of philosophy, the nondual Kashmiri Śaivism school called "Pratyabhijñā," or "Recognition," which grew out of the work of Somānanda and his successors, Utpaladeva and Abhinavagupta. The Pratyabhijñā offers a response to the monist idealisms of earlier Indian philosophical schools, the Vedānta of the eighth-century Hindu philosopher Śaṅkara and the earlier Buddhist Vijñānavāda or "mind-only" schools, both of which tended toward leaving aside material reality as illusory in their nondualist formulations of subjectivity. The Pratyabhijñā proposed a dynamic reformulation for the ideas of objectivity and subjectivity, which retained a sense of matter as real, and incorporated the notion of matter as a perspectival expression of the subject-object relation. Abhinavagupta, the great grand-disciple of Somānanda in this school's lineage, lived from about 950–1025 CE. He offered a systematic articulation of this school's philosophy, and I draw extensively from one of his last works, his *Īśvara Pratyabhijñā Vivṛti Vimarśinī, Āgamādhikāra* (*Teachings on Cosmology, the Long Commentary on Recognition*), written about 1015 CE. In the context of Indian philosophy, with its pervasive and overt leanings toward the rejection of material existence as Māyā, or "illusion," Abhinavagupta is somewhat radical in his embrace of materiality. One might read his writing as part of a larger trend within Tantric philosophy to bring the body back, recognizing the importance of the body and matter in the larger scheme of enlightenment.

Abhinavagupta accomplishes his task by locating a fundamental dynamism between subjects and objects, consciousness and matter. Specifically, he suggests that subjectivity and objectivity ought to be understood as mutually implicated, co-constituting one another. For this chapter I read Somānanda's and Abhinavagupta's mutual implication of subject and object in dialogue with Karen Barad's quantum theory of agential realism derived from Bohr's quantum theory. The differences between these models preclude any easy comparison; Abhinavagupta in particular is more concerned with establishing an overarching subjectivity as a pervasive nondualist substratum than is Barad, who stresses relationality as mutual entanglement. In this sense, Abhinavagupta's panentheist transcendent self, transforming and unfolding itself into the multitude of others is the glue that binds together subjects and others. For Barad a mutual entanglement gives birth to selves and others through their mutual, complementary differentiations. Yet the points of convergence hint at compatible ontologies; specifically, the mutual adherence they share to a foundational inseparability of subjects and objects merits closer inspection. The point of this, however, goes beyond a sense of appreciation of remarkable similarities across a gap of centuries and continents in this Bohrian-based quantum perspective and this dynamic panentheism of a medieval Indian philosopher-mystic. Rather, it suggests that this medieval conception of the body may help us as we think through our own quantum reconceptualizations of materiality.

Abhinavagupta's theories of the entanglement of consciousness and matter lead to a reconsideration of the nature of the body. Not simply inert matter, the body's parameters shift in this formulation to afford the status of "body" with a mutuality of matter and consciousness; borrowing Barad's language, we might call the body thus construed a "material-discursive" occurrence.[6] That is, Abhinavagupta's conception of the body incorporates both materiality and discursivity entwined together, an entanglement perhaps most striking in its rendition as "subtle body" (*sūkṣma śarīra*, *puryaṣṭaka*). The subtle body is certainly a body, fundamentally made of matter, yet its links with consciousness afford it capacities beyond the physical body. Not quite visible to ordinary eyesight, even as it is still connected to the five senses and is itself sensible, it is the subtle body that transmigrates from life to life for these various Indian philosophies that share an affirmation of reincarnation. Not exactly a soul here—keep in mind the idea of a soul is anathema to Buddhist contexts, which strongly affirm the "no-soul" (*anatma*) doctrine the Buddha preached around 400 BCE. The subtle body does not quite match up to the Western notion of "soul," since the Western idea of soul with its implications of a permanent and unique individual essence is problematic for these Indian nondualist traditions, even for traditions, such as Vedānta, that affirm the notion of "self" (*ātman*) as persisting beyond the death of the physical body. The subtle body is also not a cosmic self (*ātman*). It outlasts the physical body, even as it accompanies it through our daily lives, but it is subject to its own transformations. It is the body we use to dream in, to travel to distant places through yogic exercises without our more familiar corporeality, and it is the body we inhabit and in which we carry our particular *karmas*, propensities and habits while we look for new bodies in which to take birth between lives. For our purposes here, the fantastic, spiritualist conception of reincarnation need not distract us from what is useful about this concept. Untenable, we might even say scientifically distasteful, to contemporary Western sensibilities, nevertheless, an attentiveness to this unfamiliar map of the body allows us to glean unexpected and useful novel formulations of the relation between body and mind. The subtle body particularly demonstrates a permeability in its ontological characterization, entangling both materiality/body *and* consciousness as productions of ritual performance.

The Inseparability of Knowledge and Action

What Abhinavagupta and Somānanda propose in this philosophical system of "Recognition" (Pratyabhijñā) is a way of linking consciousness with matter. This is no small matter. The pervasive Cartesianism that Barad (and Bohr) reject,[7] which places a wall between the consciousness and materiality, also surfaces in its own form in an Indian context beginning early in Indian philosophical history, with Sāṃkhya, around of the turn of the first millennium.[8] Arguably the basic template and bedrock of most Indian models of cosmology, Sāṃkhya proposes twenty-five basic categories for "what there is," ranging from the five great elements (water, earth, air, fire, and space) up to primordial, sentient spirit (*puruṣa*). Most succeeding Indian philosophical systems draw from the model Sāṁkhya offers, modifying the basic system with a host of additions and innovations to present variations on a theme. In the basic Sāṁkhya template, sentience and consciousness is a property of only one of the twenty-five categories, *puruṣa* or spirit, at the apex of the system. The other twenty-four categories present modulated expressions of a primordial and fundamentally insentient Nature (*prakṛti*), incorporating all else that we encounter materially.

The philosophical counter to his Sāṃkhya inheritance that Abhinavagupta uses to arrive at the mutual implication of matter and consciousness—the fundamental inseparability of clay pots, gods, and human awareness—might be said to boil down to a basic, even psychological, apprehension of the bodily links between awareness and actions. Abhinavagupta structures his arguments for the nondual pervasiveness of consciousness, even as it transforms into matter (that is, into pots that exist because they know themselves) around the convertibility of knowledge and action into each other. Why knowledge and action? He understands the ramifications of a split between consciousness and matter to reach its way down into a mundane bifurcation of human capacities to know and to do. Consciousness is at base about knowing; matter is at base about action, about the forces that move objects. This logic also plays out in our contemporary formulations of subjectivity; the phenomenological experience of *qualia*, unadulterated consciousness, eludes neuroscientific formulations of brain operations, to the extent that they can only be bracketed out as "epiphenomena." The capacity to know is separated from our bodies' capacities to move, to sense.

The notion that knowledge and action are linked is a fundamental premise of the Pratyabhijñā system. Utpaladeva, who writes the *Verses on Recognition* (the root text for Abhinavagupta's commentary) says, "Knowledge and actions are inseparably mutually associated with the Subject."[9] This goes against the larger metaphysical milieu of India's historical bifurcation of these two. This verse proposes to bring materiality back within the sphere of consciousness. Abhinavagupta glosses this verse with, "Consciousness, which has a form possessing attributes, with a body made of the energy of knowledge [*jñāna śakti*] accepts as its attribute the power of action [*kriyā śakti*], which has the nature of both externality and internality."[10] Here again we see the body (*vapuḥ*) return, knowledge itself characterized as a body. For Abhinavagupta the link between knowledge and action is an expansion; it involves a dynamism, a movement that operates on cosmic theological scales and in a person's mental processes. He tells us:

> From the perspective of mere consciousness lying in the core there exists the state containing both inner and outer. However, differentiation [*Māyā*'s creation] spreads out, expands into many branches, with the Lord still lying within the core. And that creation is two-fold still when the energy of the highest *Śiva* spreads open. When that energy manifests inwardly, naturally it is called the energy of Knowledge. However, when it expands in stages with its active, self-reflective awareness [*vimarśa*] gradually becoming more firm and fixed, then it manifests externally. This is pointed to as the energy of Activity.[11]

Abhinavagupta's theological language points to mental processes; an inwardly directed attention entails knowledge. An externally directed attention is directed by a capacity for self-reflective insight, *vimarśa*, which itself is the basis for action. Thus *vimarśa*, which literally translates as "distinguishing touch," involves a kind of self-measuring.[12] Over time, this process of internal measurement leads to a congealing of awareness, becoming firmer and more fixed, which then affords external manifestation. Barad's notion of matter as substance in its becoming as a "congealment of agency"[13] finds a curious parallel in Abhinavagupta's theological understanding of the firming up of active awareness, *vimarśa*, the capacity for a self-reflective, self constitution through a kind of self measurement to gradually become externalized action and then objects. Barad's understanding of knowledge is that "knowing is a material practice of engagement as part of the world in its differential becoming."[14] If we reflect (diffract?) this understanding through Somānanda's clay pot who knows by means of my self in a mutual emergence of self-other knowledge, we engage in the fundamental operation of consciousness. This is the sense of *vimarśa*, self-reflective measuring, touching and engaging between me and the clay pot, to generate an entanglement that is knowledge.

Even here, however, we note the prioritization of subjectivity in Abhinavagupta's delineation of the mental processes that transform knowledge into action, and then ultimately objects. Abhinavagupta links the object back to consciousness through a kind of subjective trace that remains an inward attribute of objects:

> The Subject's form, which is a unity of consciousness, contains an excess, an abundance of awareness. This is deposited into the side of the object that is going to be created. So inwardly the object has the attribute of *śakti*, energy which is none other than the form of consciousness.[15]

The object comes into being in conjunction with the subject; the excess of awareness forms the inside of the object. Still, even as Abhinavagupta insists on the essential unity of the subject and object, each one comes to the fore at the expense of the other in a complementarity that sees either a position of subjectivity predominating or a position of object predominating. Two things we should keep in mind here: For most of what we encounter in the world, we find a mix of both subjectivity and object alternating in expression. So when we humans, in the middle of this great unfolding of Nature (*prakṛti*), reflect on a pristine sense of "I-ness" (*ahantā*), particularly (but not exclusively) in an experience of wonder (*camatkāra*), we then access our inherent sense of subjectivity. However, when we reflect, for instance, instead on "this-ness" (*idantā*), considering, for instance, "I am fat" or "I am sad," we transform our inherent subjectivity into a state that blossoms into the predominance of one or other of the five classical elements (earth, water, fire, air, and ether). In the case of thinking "I am fat," we allow the earth element to predominate, and the element of water in the thought, "I am sad."[16] Perhaps even just rescripting these types of self-identifications in terms of a subjectivity aligned with the five elements might happily jolt us out of the doldrums that often arise from these kinds of thoughts. Might Abhinavagupta say that the prevalence of this kind of culturally pervasive self-deprecation arises from a self-exile from subjectivity, "I-ness" as *ahantā*? Cultural norms aside, it is also the case that Abhinavagupta often favors the perspective of subjectivity over that of object, stressing its priority and desirability. Moreover, like Bohr's cane (discussed below), we also see a complementarity in the relation between the subject perspective and the object perspective. In response to his fabricated interlocutor, a seemingly frustrated materialist, Abhinavagupta says:

> Now you may say, well if it occurs in this way, then if one can see the form of consciousness even in a clay pot, then what is there that's not false? Yes, correct, [Utpaladeva] says, "but it is appropriate to view the insentient" in this way. . . . By removing the form which is insentient, we allow the form which is sentient, the conscious, to take predominance and there we have a complete entrance into consciousness. This is moving forward and entering into its own form.[17]

Here while Abhinavagupta asserts a primary subjectivity at base, even for the clay pot, he shies away from Somānanda's stronger formulation, which ascribes a lively subjectivity to clay. In this respect, Somānanda demonstrates a pantheism in relation to Abhinavagupta's panentheism. Abhinavagupta, cautiously shrinking away from the radical agency Somānanda gives to the clay pot, cites Utpaladeva's explanation, that it is "appropriate" to view the clay pot in this way, recognizing its inherent consciousness, its subjectivity, precisely because our perspective, our way of seeing the clay pot, affects the clay pot's own ontological status. Our seeing it as sentient allows the clay pot's capacity for sentience to come to the forefront. Here we can read this in two ways. On the one hand, we might read again the one-sided human determination of what matter is: Human consciousness makes the pot conscious. On the other hand, we might also read this transformation of the ontological status of the clay pot affected by how we think of it as a stress on a mutuality. This mutuality derives from the entanglement of the person who sees the clay pot and the pot's own reality. Because our act of viewing, indeed a kind of measurement, brings forth the status of the pot, there is a mutuality in the emergence of the pot's life. Our view of the clay pot constrains the pot's own emergence into its own inherent consciousness, though here it is important to keep in mind that the human does not animate the pot, give it life through a human capacity. Rather, the clay pot already has its own innate life. In any case, the reverse of this is also true, particularly for Somānanda. Utpala, as he comments on Somānanda's assertion of the radical agency of pots, tells us that for Somānanda, "Śiva does not exist in the form of pots, etc., but rather the pots, etc., have Śiva as their form."[18] With this, Somānanda and Utpala emphasize that the model is not of a universal life principle pervading things like pots, but rather that things themselves condition the form of consciousness, as the clay pot emerges into its form as Śiva, absolute deity and principle of consciousness.

Abhinavagupta, in contrast, more conservative than Somānanda, ascribes natural limits to certain forms. Humans, for Abhinavagupta, more easily access subjectivity and can help objects access their own subjectivity by recognizing this capacity within them. I am reminded here of Jane Bennett's poetic encounter with debris, a beat-up old white bottle cap, a single discarded black work glove, a smooth stick, all vibrating with a palpable intensity of vitality for her on a vibrant June morning.[19] In this case, Abhinavagupta's description suggests that Bennett's recognition of the vitality within this litter affords the deep and vibrant life of these only seeming lifeless objects to shine forth (*ābhāsa*) in a way that allows both object and observer to tap into the wonder of subjectivity.

Abhinavagupta's remark points to a human responsibility to act generously, to allow the clay pot's inherent sentience to actually arise. One can thus glimpse an implicit ethics in Utpaladeva's "it is appropriate." We also see here the mechanism of complementarity. Either the form of insentience (jaḍarūpa) or consciousness (cidrūpa) will be predominant. As one rises, the other falls. This complementarity still nevertheless values sentience as a kind of ground zero base reality that can shift into either its *esse* as consciousness or into insentience.

The Subtle Body

Just as the mind is physical in this medieval linking of matter and consciousness, so also the body's matter is always imbued with its own incorporeal consciousness. Writing in a medieval Indian Tantric context, Abhinavagupta inherits an already sophisticated model of body as both physical and nonmaterial, including a map of a counterpart to the corporeal body, a nonphysical body, literally, a "subtle body," known as the *sūkṣma śarīra*, *liṅga śarīra*. These models of body develop a focused attention on nonphysical centers located at precise points in the physical body that interact with the physical body, the *cakra* system. With this also come ideas of a psychophysical force located within the physical body, the *kuṇḍalinī*, which rises through different areas in the physical body and ultimately brings with its motion enlightenment for the person whose *kuṇḍalinī* is awakened. A universally present liveliness, understood as deity, a goddess, residing at the base of the spine, this psychophysical force is understood as nonmaterial, and yet it is capable of generating material effects, such as a spontaneous whirling motions of the physical body (*ghurṇita*) often accompanied by euphoria that the meditator feels as the *kuṇḍalinī* rises, among a host of other phenomena.

The Tantric body is therefore both physical and nonphysical. A hybrid entity, it contains both what we think of as physical and also what we would think of as mentality or immaterial being. The familiar physicality of the body is enhanced by an unseen energy pervading, not equally across the body, but differentially in various locations both generating and signaling material effects. In a Tantric context, very far from our own conceptual understandings of causality, some of these effects promise the prospect of using this access to this immaterial energy to gain supernatural powers such as reading other persons' minds, seeing into the future, among others.[20] Moreover, through a discursive performativity entailed within ritual practices, the practitioner engages and awakens various components of a body that is in its subtle form, directing the transformations of the physicality with which it is entangled. Thus ritual performances often enact a reformulation of the body. For example, one visualizes one's body, frequently for instance in Buddhism, as the body of a deity, among a variety of other visualization practices. Similarly, a ubiquitous Hindu practice[21] involves visualizing the sequential destruction of one's physical body and its replacement with a body made of mantras, ritual formulas understood to be deities, which are then placed in various parts of the physical body, the top of the head, the throat, the heart, and so on. This type of practice suggests that the physical body is amenable to discursive transformations through language and through visualization.[22]

For practitioners, the transformations that ritual practice bring are understood not so much as human manipulations that transform the physical body. Instead, they shift the parameters of the physical body by means of the body's already given subtle body. The subtle immaterial body has a capacity to express (connect with?)[23] the plethora of vibrant energies, and in some cases, nonmaterial beings that populate our space. If this sounds like rampant animism, it is. I suggest however, that it may be possible to think beyond the panoply of a multiplicity of spirits, to a notion of performative discursivity as a functional component always intimately connected with the physical body. Of course, this is fundamentally different from the type of bodily habits that Judith Butler points to as generating a subjectivity through discursive interpellations of culture and practice, since this discursivity accords a subjectivity to material effects of the body not governed by the human mind. Yet the inclusion of discursivity as capable of generating subjectivity is suggestive. Ultimately, I think it comes down to Abhinavagupta's suggestion that we saw earlier, that by recognizing the capacity for subjectivity in all the seeming insentient life and matter around us, we afford it the capacity to enter into its form as consciousness. The baseline understanding of the body is a recognition of its own always already present and potentially emerging subjectivity. Like the clay pot, seemingly lifeless, but with its own reservoir of subjecthood in the wings, needing only to be unleashed, the body has a life of its own that impels the subjectivity of our thoughts.

So how exactly does Abhinavagupta describe the subtle body? Abhinavagupta tells us that the subtle body "is like the physical body, but it does not have limitations in terms of its spatial dimensions."[24] Nor is it bound by the divisions of time into past and present, though it is still connected to time as a universal.[25] That is, it is not strictly bound to linear time, but still operates within a framework of time dividing the capacity for awareness. The subtle body is not a transcendent, time-free entity. This again entails a flexibility in terms of the capacity of the subtle body to travel to future and past. The subtle body is, moreover, composed of eight components. Dubbed the "City of Eight," the *puryaṣṭaka*, these eight elements include first, the five vital breaths, called *prāṇas*. These are the in-breath, the out-breath, the upward breath, the downward breath, and the breath that mixes all of these. This makes five of the eight. Along with this is the *antahkaraṇa*, the inner organ, subdivided into three, including the mind, the intellect, and the ego. Finally, two more are added to these six to make eight. These are the two groups of sense organs, the *buddhīndriya*, including the ear for hearing, the nose for smelling, and so on, and the *karmendriya*, the group of organs of action, which includes the hand, the foot, the sex organ.[26] This description of the subtle body is quite similar to what we see in Sāṁkhya and yoga.

Thus we see that this very subtle body is much like a physical body. It even contains, as essence or template, if not actually corporeally, hands and feet and genitalia. For a Western context, if we imagine an idea of what might survive death, we head into the territory of notions of "soul." And for Abhinavagupta, as for Sāṁkhya and yoga, it is this subtle body that survives bodily death and reincarnates life after life. Yet—if we imagine the idea of a "soul," do we often include components like feet and genitalia?

And yet this mix of breath (the five *prāṇas* here) and very subtle feet and hands and an ego and so on is somehow not bound by space and only minimally bound by time. Even if the notion of the subtle body operates merely as a sketch, only as a very subtle outline, Abhinavagupta is very clear that this subtle body too is really, without any doubt, unambiguously a body. He tells us,

> The City of Eight does in fact have the nature of a body, because the primary elements, fire, earth etc., inhere in it.[27] Also, here, in order to remove delusion, [Utpaladeva] uses the word "body" to describe this extremely subtle state, the subtle body, *puryaṣṭaka* precisely to instigate the reader to voice doubts about the nature of this body and the applicability that the word "body" with its physical implications entails for this subtle existence.[28]

This idea of a subtle body, a spirit body, with hands and so on, this body with spatially contoured appendages, which is however, not confined spatially, affords a polyvalent notion of the body. With this Abhinavagupta is especially at pains to reinscribe the idea of consciousness as never very far from the notion of bodies. That is, there is no space for a free-floating consciousness. There is always a body, matter of some sort emerging and interacting with awareness. Action and knowledge always coexist, entwined, unfolding mutually. The evocative, if accidental, resonances with Karen Barad's model, as she tells us, for instance, that "knowing is a material practice"[29] and that "practices of knowing and being are not insoluble. They are mutually implicated"[30] are certainly suggestive. I should note again that this notion of the subtle body is not parallel to a Western notion of soul. Although the subtle body is indeed that which transmigrates, it does not in this system carry the same notion of incorruptibility that is part of the idea of the Western soul. Rather it functions as a middle term between the physical entity that dies and some ultimate component of self—for Abhinavagupta this ultimate component would be a notion of divine subjectivity, whereas for other thinkers, such as Śaṅkara, this entails the subtle body's disappearance altogether. What then does it mean to ritually perform the refinement of this subtle body, to imagine filling it with mantras and deities? With this discursive reworking of the body, does the body talk back? Or does the subtle body come to life only if we perform it, if we habituate ourselves to a subtle materiality that accompanies the visually present physicality we engage as we move through the world?

If we understand the body in terms of a co-related discursive materiality, it affords us a polyvalent notion of the body, a body performatively enacted, yet carrying its own implicit animation, a life of the body, focused predominantly on the breaths that animate it, not so much the mind, mentality, though including this, but an animism that extends itself corporeally, a discursivity that suggests demands that the body not simply be the tool of our minds, but a materiality with its own emerging, if latent trajectories.

The Cartesian "Cut"

At this point I will tie in Abhinavagupta's conceptions of the body and subtle body with the work of contemporary theorists, especially Barad, who uses the insights of quantum mechanics to reformulate ways of thinking about materiality. I should start by pointing out that the pervasive human exceptionalism ardently criticized by posthumanism finds no real foothold in this Indian context. The assertion of the human as the privileged site of agency is not really a consideration for the vast ontological landscapes of Indian cosmology. In a world already populated with a host of uncanny others—from ghosts and tree spirits (*bhūta* and *yakṣa*) to subtle bodied beings, whose main material form is sound, to talking geese and talking bulls, even to apparently garrulous inanimate elements—a fire that talks, to demons and to gods, who even when they try to mimic humans cannot help but stand an inch or so off the ground, eyes unblinking, unsweating,[31] down to worms with their own desires—the Indian context is happily bereft of a dominant anthropocentrism. Abhinavagupta, for instance, writes, "When those [beings] belonging to *Māyā*—down to an insect—when they do their own deeds, that which is to be done first stirs in the heart,"[32] signaling the perspective and agency of a conscious insect. His predecessor Somānanda takes this dispersal of agency to even greater democratic lengths, writing: "Knowing itself as the agent, the clay pot performs its own action. If it were not aware of its own agency, the clay pot would not be present."[33] Thus the Western focus on the human, which has historically enabled a seemingly "natural" division between the human and nonhuman, and its corollaries, culture and nature, is conspicuously absent in this Indian context.[34]

Yet, lest we think the source of our postmodern woes lies in our Western inability to encounter the face of the nonhuman, there is still, even in this radically nonanthropocentric paradigm, the divisions of subjects and objects. So although the human/nonhuman division is not ever a central or logical contention, nevertheless Descartes's division of "what there is" into *res cogitans* and *res extensa*, these two domains of subjects and objects, does find a counterpart quite early in Indian tradition in Sāṁkhya, dating at least from the beginning of the third century BCE and likely much earlier.[35] In Īśvarakṛṣṇa's *Sāṃkhya Kārika*, the *res* *cogitans* finds expression in only the very first principle, that of *puruṣa,* the "primordial person."[36] All the rest, the succeeding twenty-four principles from Nature (prakṛti) down to earth, constitute the *res extensa*, everything else.

I should also stress that Indian philosophy and soteriology, particularly in many of its nondualist versions, has tended to favor the *res cogitans* component, the *puruṣa*, as the "real." That is, *puruṣa*, consciousness and spirit, is that which fundamentally exists in these several Indian philosophical systems, whereas matter is viewed with hermeneutical suspicion. Matter and bodies in this view are the product of an unreal *Māyā*, illusions churned out epiphenomenally from *prakṛti*. We might contrast this with twenty-first-century neuroscience, which takes the opposite cosmological position, suggesting that matter is what is "real," while the perception of consciousness is mere epiphenomenon.[37]

However, even as Indian cosmologies tend to favor the *res cogitans*, the parameters of this consciousness tend also to differ radically from our own Cartesian parameters. For example, Descartes's cogitating mind, the thinking voice that says "I think, therefore . . . ," stands on the side of consciousness; it is the *cogitans* in the Western bifurcation of consciousness and matter. In contrast, in the Sāṁkhyan Indian perspective, mind would not make the cut for consciousness. Rather, *manas* translated as "mind," falls squarely in the camp of *prakṛti*, Nature, in all its insentient materiality. Indian systems then, following Sāṁkhya, place the Cartesian "cut" much higher up the scale, so that intentionality (*ahaṁkāra*), insight (*buddhi*), and cogitation (*manas*) all feature as materiality.

The question of where to place the cut between consciousness and matter, and the corollary subject and object, is important for contemporary understandings of what matter is. It is important for Barad's quantum interpretation, and not only for hers. Henry Stapp, another quantum physicist concerned with formulating the role of the observer in quantum theory, offers the proposal that the cut between subject and object might be understood through quantum findings as a rethinking of Heisenberg's cut. Heisenberg initially proposed the idea of the quantum "cut" as a way out of the queer metaphysics entailed by the quantum responses of matter to observers. He posited a hypothetical dividing line between the observer or measuring apparatus in a quantum experiment and the wave function being observed. Above the line, the macroscopic paradigm of classical physics is operative; below this line of the Heisenberg "cut," the weird unpredictability of microscopic quantum systems operates as quantum wave function. Heisenberg proposed this cut as a way of addressing the collapse of the wave function in the Copenhagen interpretation of quantum mechanics. An arbitrary, theoretical construct, Heisenberg's cut nevertheless tries to manage and explain why classical objects behave in the predictable way they do and why quantum objects defy classical physics laws. Like Barad, Stapp points out the artificiality of Heisenberg's macro/micro distinction, noting that quantum theory works on both levels. Moreover, he suggests that the Heisenberg cut applies not only to matter, but also to the multifold nature of reality itself. Further, Stapp draws from von Neumann's proposal that the Heisenberg cut might apply to the distinction between the physical and the mental, rather than to the macro of classical physics and the micro of quantum mechanics. With this, Henry Stapp reinterprets the Heisenberg cut as a boundary line between the perspectives of the subject and the object.[38] That is, the cut he hypothesizes is a perspectival demarcation between consciousness and matter, and specifically, consciousness and brain. Thus, Stapp suggests moving the cut out of matter altogether, using it instead as what facilitates the connectivity between matter and mind, and thus affording a reintroduction of the observer as mind (or better, consciousness and subjectivity). Stapp's location of the cut here does not, however, reinstate a Cartesian wall between matter and mind. Rather, he uses the artificiality of Heisenberg's macro/micro distinction to point to the elephant in the room: the exclusion of mind from the equation altogether. With this, Stapp presents a possible solution to the materialist dilemma of how to account for the apparent nonmateriality of consciousness without simply whisking the notion of consciousness away as mere epiphenomenon of the gray matter inside our skulls. The mechanism he ultimately proposes for bridging between the physical and the mental is the quantum Zeno effect.[39]

The quantum Zeno effect is an empirically proven phenomenon that demonstrates that a rapid succession of measurements or observations has a capacity to influence the effects we see in the physical world. The quantum Zeno effect tells us that a rapid succession of questions—questions that originate from the observer, from the side of consciousness—will statistically alter the outcome, through some odd disposition in the order of quantum selection that somehow favors a rapid, repeated mental probing, beyond what we might expect as a statistical outcome of quantum probabilities. It bears repeating that these measurements, what Stapp terms "mental probing actions,"[40] originate on the side of consciousness, not matter, yet based on proven quantum effects, they determine the material outcomes.

Following Bohr, Karen Barad approaches the idea of Heisenberg's cut in an altogether different way from the way Stapp approaches it. She points to the contingent and dynamic nature of the cut between subject and object, telling us, "as Bohr says, there is no inherently determinate Cartesian cut,"[41] and

> the specification of the conditions necessary for an unambiguous account of quantum phenomena is tantamount *to the introduction of a constructed, agentially enacted, materially conditioned and embodied, contingent Bohrian cut between an object and the agencies of observation*.[42]

That is, the location of the cut is not predetermined. Its position changes with the material conditions we use to ascertain it, following on the materially embodied apparatus that is used to make measurements. If we understand the idea of the cut as the possibility of demarcating the differential relationship between subjects and objects, in this case the observer and the object measured, then Barad's dynamic formulation forces us to rethink the stability of the demarcation. To point out the contingent nature of the cut between subject and object, she draws on Bohr's lively metaphor of a person with a cane in a dark room that he used to explain the notion of complementarity:

> One need only remember here the sensation, often cited by psychologists, which everyone has experienced when attempting to orient himself in a dark room with a stick. When the stick is held loosely, it appears to the sense of touch to be an object. When, however, it is held firmly, we lose the sensation that it is a foreign body, and the impression of touch becomes immediately localized at the point where the stick is touching the body under investigation.[43]

Whether this object, the cane, takes on the position of subject or the position of object depends here on whether it functions as the measuring instrument for the human or as an object the human holds in his or her hands and examines. Barad highlights the "complementarity," or mutual exclusivity, entailed by each of these usages. Here function determines status, whether subject or object, in mutually exclusive states. The same material structure, the cane, alternately performs both these functions. The cut between these two demarcations of status, that is, its *identity* as subject or object, depends on an emergent functionality.

Abhinavagupta also highlights this feature of the lability of subject and object, even as he frames this mobility of subject and object as marked through grammatical interpellation, rather than Barad's and Bohr's "unambiguous and reproducible marks on bodies."[44] Quoting a maxim of his school, Abhinavagupta draws from grammar to illustrate how objectivity and subjectivity are mobile perspectives. He says, "<HS>'Everything in fact has the nature of all things.' Even the lifeless [grammatical] third person, [the "it"], if it sheds its lifeless form can take on the first and second person forms [the grammatical I and you]. For example, 'Listen, o stones' and 'Of mountains, I am Meru.'<HS>"[45] In other words, apparently lifeless stones and a mountain in the distance do not inherently, by virtue of their seeming insentience, remain confined to the category of object. Rather, as we saw earlier with Abhinavagupta's clay pot that accesses its sentience in tandem with our awareness of it and with Jane Bennett's vibrant entanglement with debris, if we engage a stone as a "you" instead of a distant third person, "it," we open a way to a mutual and vital subjectivity. We should here keep in sight the language of agency Abhinavagupta uses for the insentient stone;[46] the stone itself, as Abhinavagupta tells us in the quote above, "sheds its lifeless form." Although appearing insentient (*jaḍa*),[47] it is the agent of its own change. Moreover, the cut between insentient matter and sentient consciousness is mobile, always available for repositioning, even for something like a stone.

Abhinavagupta's idea that "everything in fact has the nature of all things" points to a fundamental nondualism that emerges dynamically into correlated, even entangled components. Within a context of interrelation, we might venture a comparison to Barad's "intra-action." As we saw in the epigraph for this chapter, Somānanda articulates the interrelationality of clay pot, human, and god in a mutual emergence that looks on the surface to be an unapologetic pantheistic animism: "The clay pot knows by means of my self and I know by means of the self of the clay pot. . . . Indeed, the clay pot knows by means of that absolute transcendent being and the transcendent deity knows by means of the clay pot."[48] Human knowledge is on a par with the knowingness of both gods and clay pots. Further, knowledge itself is generated through a relationality between these. Insofar as the knowledge of self and god and clay pot arise through each other, Somānanda's model approaches the intra-activity that Barad points. My sense of knowing is contingent on my interaction with the clay pot; a mutuality of self-awareness arises specifically through the engagement and articulation of our subjectivities through each other. These two are co-constituted. The matrix for this mutual emergence is precisely the potentiality of a subjectivity always in the wings, as a fundamental component constituting both matter *and* consciousness. It is this prospect of a universal subjectivity, a ubiquitous and democratic citizenship of the self that makes the recovery, the recognition (*pratyabhijñā*) of inherent divinity (might we substitute for a twenty-first-century Western materialism the notion of an inherent matter-worthiness?) always available, even for something which to our modern eyes seems so hopelessly matter-bound as a clay pot.

So from this maxim of "everything in fact has the nature of all things," we arrive at a nondualism premised on a fundamental inseparability of the subject and object. Barad also rests her mutual inseparability on a nondualism. She emphasizes, "Phenomena constitute a nondualistic whole"[49] and "Phenomena are the ontological inseparability of intra-acting agencies."[50] For Barad the apparatus, which includes the machinery used to record the measures taken (the location of the electron, for instance), entails "boundary drawing practices."[51] For Abhinavagupta, the notion of apparatus is less coherent; the apparatus in his schema might perhaps be understood as the unfolding of consciousness in its various and relative reflections of *ahantā*—the state of being subject—and *idantā*, the state of being object. So although I emphasize their commonality in embracing the inseparability of subject and object, it is important not to minimize the difference of apparatus between these two nondualisms. Abhinavagupta's nondualism entails a dynamic unfolding of a singular reality; subjectivity unfolds itself into matter and objects. It never loses its innate subjectivity; yet it forgets this subjectivity in the position of being object. The Pratyabhijñā "Recognition" hints about a way of recognizing an always available vitality of subjecthood.

One other related substantive difference is, in fact, the notion of substance. Whereas Barad emphasizes *relation* over relata,[52] Abhinavagupta retains a primordial substantiality in the notion of consciousness (*cid*) which is at the heart of both objects and subjects, even if he redefines this substance of consciousness to enact a fundamental dynamism within it.

Despite these differences, we might nevertheless profitably redirect and extend some components of these medieval insights to afford ourselves in the twenty-first century other options for thinking about matter and the body. The body is by all counts pervasive in Abhinavagupta's conception of consciousness. He tells us, "The highest principle, the essence of consciousness alone is the body [*vapuḥ*] of all beings,"[53] and "the highest principle is indeed the body of all things."[54] The image of body derives from a pervasive philosophical instantiation of consciousness qua materiality, where the substance of consciousness unfolds as the materiality of the world, "on the wall of itself the picture of all entities,"[55] generating a kind of space-time fabric out of itself. That is, like Barad's notion that entities are "material demarcations not *in* but *of* space,"[56] here, entities arise out of and move within the fabric that is consciousness itself. Deriving from the *Spandakārikā*, a root text for this philosophical school, the image entails the unfolding of consciousness into materiality that is the world, matter, bodies, and differentiation itself.[57]

Notes

<<AU: The comments feature doesn't work in the notes, so I will place my queries and comments within double angle brackets, usually at the end of the note, and highlighted in yellow usually, though sometimes in green. If a response is needed, please make any additions or corrections to the note, or add a comment after the two virgules.// >>

[1] See Latour's critique of criticism, which applies particularly in this vein to the social sciences, in Bruno Latour, "Why Has Critique Run out of Steam? From Matters of Fact to Matters of Concern" *Critical Inquiry* 30, no. 2 (2004): 235.

[2] Here, literally boggling the mind. Patricia Churchland, *Touching a Nerve: The Self as Brain* (New York: W. W. Norton, 2013). Daniel Dennett's work offers a similar extension of materialism to write out the notion of subjective self.

[3] Not to mention its negative reverberations in the United States and Europe.

[4] David Kaiser, *How the Hippies Saved Physics: Science, Counterculture and the Quantum Revival* (New York: W. W. Norton, 2012), 53. Special thanks to Mary-Jane Rubenstein for connecting this point to Kaiser's work and for her especially thoughtful and helpful suggestions throughout this article.

[5] Somānanda, *Śivadṛṣṭi*, 5.106–7. For the first translation into English of this complex Sanskrit text, see John Nemec's excellent translation and study: John Nemec, *Ubiquitous Śiva: Somānanda's Śivadṛṣṭi and His Tantric Interlocutors* (New York: Oxford University Press, 2012).

[6] Karen Barad, *Meeting the Universe Halfway: Quantum Physics and the Entanglement of Matter and Meaning* (Durham, N.C.: Duke University Press 2007), 335.

[7] Ibid., 125, 130–131.

[8] One early classical expression of Sāṃkhya is Īśvarakṛṣṇa's roughly third century CE Sāṃkhya Kārika, however various permutations of Sāṃkhya were in circulation probably as early as the fourth century BCE. See Gerald Larson, *Classical Sāṃkhya: An Interpretation of Its History and Meaning* (Delhi: Motilal Banarsidass, 1969).

[9] *Īśvara Pratyabhijñā kārikā*: 3.1. Utpaladeva was Abhinavagupta's predecessor and teacher of Abhinavagupta's teachers.

[10] Abhinavagupta, *Īśvara Pratyabhijñā Vivṛti Vimarśinī* (IPVV), 3 vols., ed. Paṇḍit Madhusudan Kaul Shāstrī (Delhi: Akay Reprints, 1985), 3:257: jñāna śakti vapuṣā dharmirūpaḥ san tām antarbahirātmatām kramikāvabhāsām kriyā śaktim dharmatvena svīkurute iti.

[11] Ibid., 3:262.

[12] Ibid., 3:258. I translate vimarśa as "active awareness" to keep the inherent connection with action that vimarśa entails; however, Mark Dyczkowski, encountering the term in other texts of this school translates it as self-reflection.

[13] Barad, *Meeting the Universe Halfway*, 184.

[14] Ibid., 91.

[15] IPVV, 3:258.

[16] Ibid., 3:280.

[17] Ibid., 3:315: Nanu evaṃ ghate 'pi yadi cidrūpatām kaścit paśyet, tarhi kim abhrānta eva asau. Om ity āha "jaḍasya tu" iti "Yukta eva" iti ucita evety arthaḥ. . . . ayaṃ samyag iti jaḍarūpatānyakkriyayā cidrūpatāprādhānyena āveśaḥ ā samantāt svarūpapraveśaḥ ity arthaḥ.

[18] Nemec, *Śivadṛṣṭi*, 270.

[19] Jane Bennett, *Vibrant Matter: A Political Ecology of Things* (Durham, N.C.: Duke University Press 2010), 4.

[20] These are the *siddhi*-s, magical powers, historically one of the primary reasons a Tantric practitioner takes on particular ritual practices.

[21] Bhūta śuddhi

[22] See Gavin Flood, *The Tantric Body: The Secret Tradition of Hindu Religion* (London: I. B. Taurus, 2006).

[23] The philosophical cosmology of a particular system determines the answer to this.

[24] IPVV, 3:306.

[25] Ibid.

[26] Ibid., 3:334.

[27] Via the connection of the subtle elements to the sense organs.

[28] IPVV, 3:306.

[29] Barad, *Meeting the Universe Halfway*, 342.

[30] Ibid., 185.

[31] The twin gods of the morning and evening star, the Aświns, try to pass as the human suitor Nala in the Nala and Damayantī love story in the Mahābhārata. Here we also encounter a talking goose, as we do a talking bull, various talking birds and a fire that talks as well in Satyakāma's story, Chandogya Upaniṣad, 4.4.1–4.9.3 in *Upaniṣads*, trans. from the Original Sanskrit by Patrick Olivelle (New York: Oxford University Press, 1996), 130–33.

[32] IPVV, 3:260.

[33] *Śiva Dṛṣṭi* 5.16: jānan kartāramātmānaṃ ghaṭaḥ kuryāt svakāṃ kriyām/ajñāte svātmakartṛtve na ghaṭaḥ sampravartate. See also John Nemec's fine critical edition and translation of the first three chapters of this seminal text, John Nemec, *Ubiquitous Śiva* (New York: Oxford University Press, 2012).

[34] In fact, the medieval Śaiva context for instance, does not even employ the species-dependent formula for categorization. Rather, the classification here falls into seven levels of beings: (1) sakala, (2) pralayākala, (3) vijñānākala, (4) mantra, (5) mantreśvara, (6) mahāmantreśvara, (7) Śiva. Some systems add more or different categories—Vidyeśvaras, for instance. in some classifications. The system of classification derives from ontological priority based on degrees of manifestation of subjectivity. Thus, a being on the level of mantra (some gods, for instance) displays a greater sense of awareness that what exists is not different from one's own self than the entity at the level of vijñānākala, who understands the essential unity of reality but not to the degree to be able to act in the world as a god (at the level of mantra) might. These distinctions can cut across species; a particular animal, a crow or a cow, might attain a level of vijñānākala (literally, the one who has unbroken awareness) or mantreśvara, whereas a human at the level of sakala (literally, containing internal divisions) might not. These differences are ontological and appear in some cases to specifically pertain to that entity's capacity for greater or lesser effective action in the world. The notion of species in this context is, in contrast, more ephemeral, perhaps due to the idea in Patanjali, *Yoga Sūtra,* 2.13, that species can change from birth to birth dependent on karma.

[35] I have argued elsewhere that it is precisely this distinction of the thinking mind as already on the side of matter fundamentally that David Chalmers points out in his discussion of the difference between the phenomenal and the psychological components of consciousness. In Loriliai Biernacki, "A Cognitive Science View of Abhinavagupta's Understanding of Consciousness," *Religions* 5, no. 3 (2014): 767–79.

[36] *Sāṃkhya Kārika*, 19–20. Larson, *Classical Sāṃkhya*, 265. The "*puruṣa*" is as we might expect always translated as male gender; I am taking license here to universalize it to person rather than "male person." Descartes's references to the *res cogitans* and *res extensa* come from his Second Meditation, II.08 in René Descartes, *Meditations on First Philosophy*, ed. Stanley Tweyman (New York: Routledge 1993), 34–40.

[37] For instance, Daniel Dennett, *Consciousness Explained* (Boston: Little, Brown, 1991).

[38] Henry Stapp, "A Quantum Mechanical Theory of the Mind/Brain Connection" in Ed Kelly, Paul Marshall, Adam Crabtree eds., *Beyond Physicalism: Toward Reconciliation of Science and Spirituality* (New York: Rowman and Littlefield 2015) , 166-169.

[39] Ibid., 168, 173.

[40] Stapp uses the term "mental probing actions" as a corollary to what von Neumann terms an "abstract ego." For Stapp the mental probing of a consciousness maintains "a quantum dynamical linkage to its associated physical brain" (ibid., 165, 172-3, 181).

[41] Barad, *Meeting the Universe Halfway*, 114.

[42] Ibid., 115.

[43] Bohr quoted ibid., 154, used also by Merleau-Ponty with a different sense, Barad points out. <<AU: What is "used also by Merleau-Ponty"?// >><<Okay to change "she" to "Barad"?//>>

[44] Ibid., 320. Barad uses this criteria from Bohr as the definition of objectivity. For instance, she quotes Bohr on 119: "<HS>'Objective' means reproducible and unambiguously communicable—in the sense that 'permanent marks . . . [are] left on bodies which define the experimental conditions" (taken from Bohr in Henry J. Folse, *The Philosophy of Niels Bohr: The Framework of Complementarity* (New York: North Holland Physics Publishing, 1985), 15. <<Please place the ending single quotation mark that goes with the one before "permanent marks."//>>

[45] Abhinavagupta, *Parātrīśikavivaraṇa*, downloaded from GRETIL: Gottingen Register of Electronic Texts in Indian Languages: http://gretil.sub.uni-goettingen.de/gretil/1_sanskr/6_sastra/3_phil/saiva/partrvpu.htm, 212: sarvaṃ hi sarvātmakam iti. narātmāno jaḍā api tyaktatatpūrvarūpāḥ śāktaśaivarūpabhājo bhavanti, śṛṇuta grāvāṇaḥ [cf. Mahābhāṣya 3.1.1; cf. Vākyapadīya 3 Puruṣasamuddeśa 2], meruḥ śikhariṇām ahaṃ bhavāmi (Bhagavadgītā 10.23).

[46] The Sanskrit makes this apparent: literally, "Those who have the essence of nara (man/human—here referring to the third person, the "it" of the stone), having abandoned that earlier form, they become beings who partake of the śākta-second person and Śaiva-first person forms." No external agency is invoked here.

[47] Here Abhinavagupta's and Somānanda's insistence on the innate consciousness and sentience of the stone is the exception to a long tradition in India that begins with Sāṃkhya demarcating between matter and consciousness. As noted earlier, Sāṃkhya tends to consider only consciousness sentient, and even mind and intellect fall on the side of insentient nature, not to mention stones. Abhinavagupta, Somānanda, and Utpaladeva are radical in their ascription of consciousness even to matter.

[48] Somānanda, *Śiva Dṛṣṭi* 5.105–7.

[49] Barad, *Meeting the Universe Halfway*, 205.

[50] Ibid., 206.

[51] Ibid.

[52] Ibid., 139.

[53] IPVV, 3:257: Tad eva ca sarvabhāvānām pāramārthikam vapuḥ.

[54] Ibid.: Śivatattvaṁ hi sarva padārthānām vapuḥ.

[55] Ibid.: Tad bhitta pṛṣṭhe ca sarva bhāva citra nirbhāsa.

[56] Barad, *Meeting the Universe Halfway*, 181.

[57] This derives from the Spanda Karika opening metaphor, where consiousness paints the picture of the world out of its own self, SpK Nirṇaya:1.1: svasvarūpātsvatantrasvacchasvātmasvabhittau kalayati dharaṇītaḥ śivāntaṃ sadā yā. <<SpK okay?//>>